Why dogs pull on the leash

A professional insight for dog parents

by
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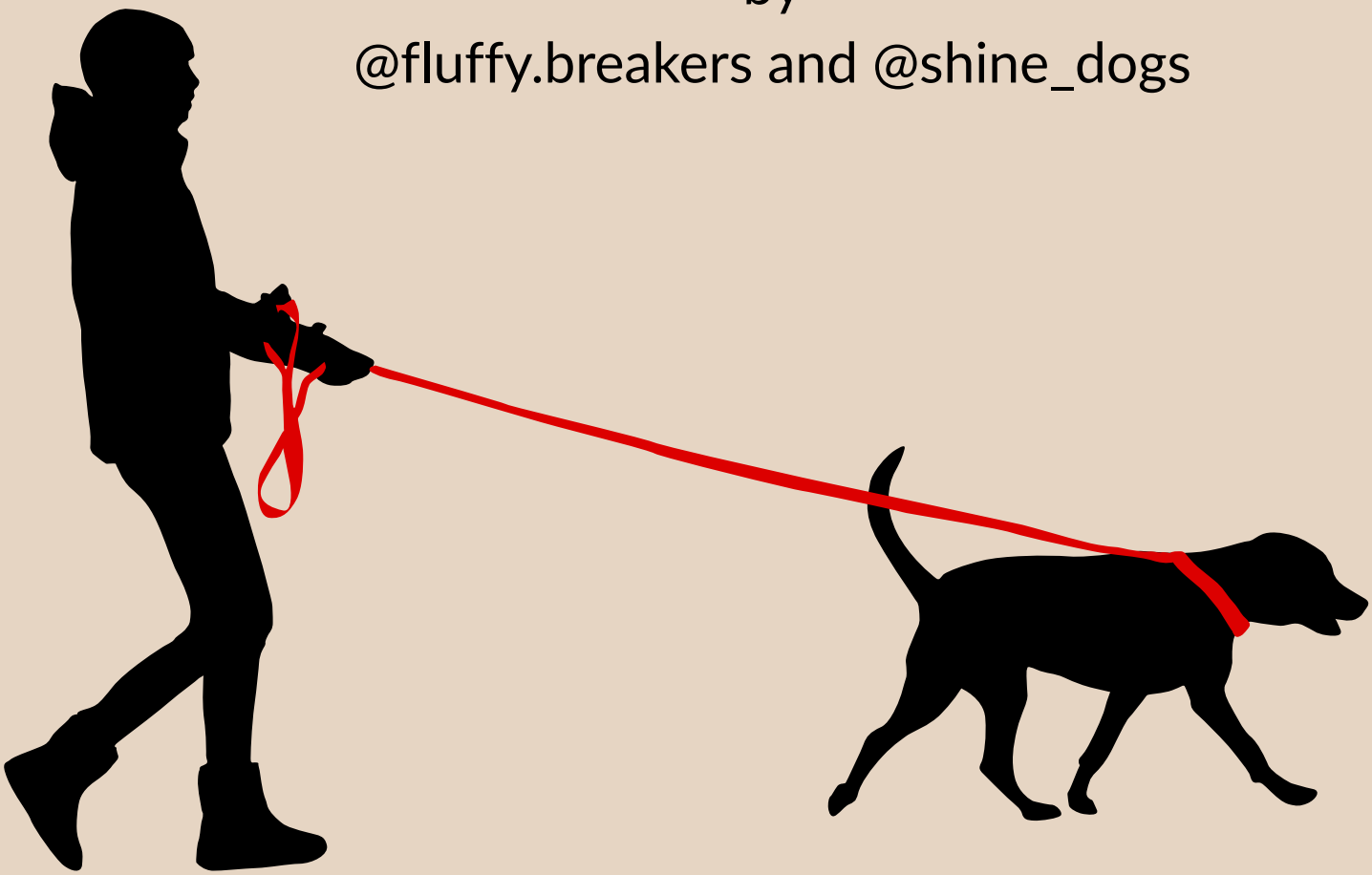


It is not just obedience

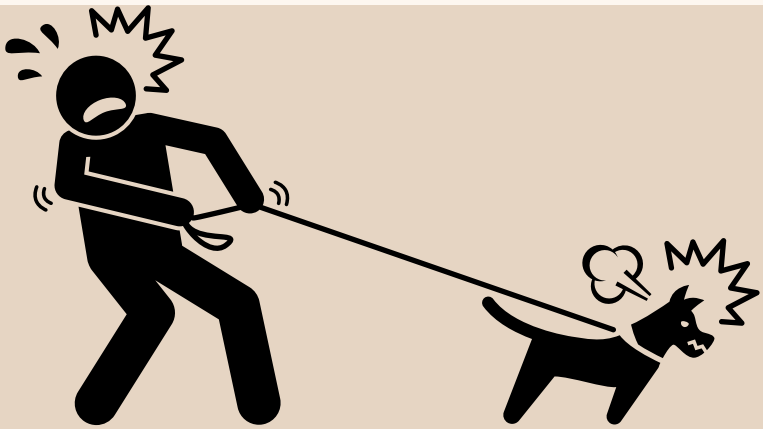
Teaching a dog to walk on a loose leash is not just a matter of obedience. Pulling is influenced by individual traits, emotional state, environment, and even the gear you use. Let's look at the real reasons behind pulling - some may surprise you.

The dog: needs, temperament and genetics

- **Unmet needs:** Dogs who have long walks infrequently (e.g., once a week) are likely to pull out of sheer excitement or desperation.
- **Breed tendencies:** Some dogs were bred to pull (sled dogs), chase (sighthounds, terriers), or range far (gundogs). It's not "bad behavior", it's DNA.
- **Emotional state:** Overexcitement, anxiety or fear may override training. A stressed or overstimulated dog cannot focus.
- **Health & comfort:** Pain, discomfort or temperature sensitivity can result in pulling or erratic movement.
- **Physical capacity:** *Fun fact!* Dogs have four legs and naturally walk faster than we do. This mismatch in pace should not be underestimated.

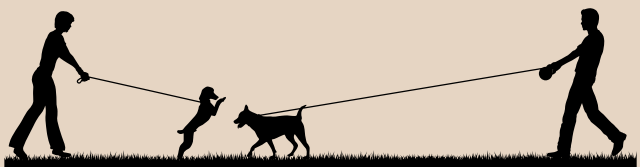
Before the walk routine reflects the walk

- If your dog heads out the door full of excitement, don’t be surprised if the whole walk feels like a race.
- Preparation and decompression before walking are essential.
- Sniffing, searching and enrichment games *before* and *during* walks can reduce pulling and increase engagement.
- Don’t expect calm focus right out the door.



Environment, gear and human influence

- **Leash length:** A short leash often creates constant tension, leading to more pulling.
- **Retractable leashes:** These are best suited for calm, well-regulated dogs in low-stimulation environments.
- **Leash handling:** A tense or reactive handler can reinforce pulling. The dog pulls, the human tightens, the dog pulls harder.
- **Walking surface & weather:** Cold, heat, slipperiness or discomfort from clothing can change the behavior significantly.
- **Daily life:** Dogs who live in quiet or rural areas may not be accustomed to urban stimulation and restrictions.
- **Human emotions:** A nervous, rushed or overly controlling handler can affect the dog's comfort and pace. Human tension travels down the leash.
- **Attachment & safety:** Dogs that feel unsure or scared around their person may try to keep their distance during walks.



Professional recommendations

- Increase the frequency and variety of walks to reduce tension and overexcitement.
- Some dogs pull or resist because they feel unsafe outside. In these cases, it's important to gradually build confidence by adjusting the duration (shorter walks) and intensity (fewer triggers, calmer environments) of the walks.
- Allow for decompression time - sniffing, exploring and choice-based movement.
- Practice loose leash skills in calm, familiar environments before increasing difficulty.
- Choose dog gear that supports comfort and communication, not control through force.
- Always observe behavior with curiosity: pulling is communication, not defiance.

Behavior is communication.
Be curious, be kind, be present.
Let your dog walk with you — not just behind you.

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